

Evaluating AI Use: A Relationships-First Lens

Use: Choose a dimension → ask the question → evaluate whether AI supports or substitutes for learning.

(Credit for these dimensions goes to <https://openedculture.org/projects/dimensions-of-ai-literacies/>)

Row	Cultural	Cognitive	Constructive	Communicative	Confident	Creative	Critical	Civic
Question	Q1 Whose perspectives or context shape this AI use? How do our community norms shape when and how we use AI?	Q2 Does AI build or bypass the student's thinking? What should humans think through, and what can AI responsibly assist with?	Q3 What is the student constructing through AI use? How do we build with AI while maintaining authorship and attribution?	Q4 Who is communicating, and with what accountability? How does how we talk to AI shape what we get back?	Q5 Does AI increase agency or dependence? How do we learn through failure and iteration with AI?	Q6 Does AI open possibilities the student can develop? How can AI enable new forms of meaningful learning?	Q7 How is the AI output questioned or verified? What should never be delegated to AI?	Q8 Who is affected by this AI use? How does AI use affect relationships, equity, and community?
Supports Positive Example	P1 <i>Hypothetical:</i> Student compares perspectives, then explains one in their own words. <i>Actual:</i> Instructor visibly models AI use during class to establish shared norms of competent practice.	P2 <i>Hypothetical:</i> Student asks AI for hints, then solves and explains the problem. <i>Actual:</i> Emphasis on systems thinking, translation, toolbox building, and iterative design.	P3 <i>Hypothetical:</i> Student uses AI feedback to revise a draft they authored. <i>Actual:</i> Custom chatbots built from course materials to support interactive learning.	P4 <i>Hypothetical:</i> Student uses AI to clarify wording before discussing with peers. <i>Actual:</i> AI prompted as a collaborative “fellow classmate” supporting discourse and honesty.	P5 <i>Hypothetical:</i> Student uses AI to prepare questions they can ask confidently. <i>Actual:</i> Instructor models trial-and-error use of AI in real time, including mistakes.	P6 <i>Hypothetical:</i> Student generates options, then chooses and develops one. <i>Actual:</i> AI-assisted presentations followed by live Q&A to verify understanding.	P7 <i>Hypothetical:</i> Student checks AI claims against course materials and sources. <i>Actual:</i> “Do not automate the work that brings intrinsic reward to the one who does it.”	P8 <i>Hypothetical:</i> Student considers fairness, access, and consequences before using AI. <i>Actual:</i> AI used to support trust, shared presence, and authentic community.
Substitutes Negative Example	N1 Students bypass instructional materials with undisclosed AI summaries, shifting norms silently.	N2 AI generates surface-level outputs without real understanding or engagement.	N3 AI produces final work with no student revision or ownership.	N4 AI speaks for the student without disclosure or understanding.	N5 Student cannot proceed without AI approval or wording. Failure is hidden; no shared process of learning with AI.	N6 AI chooses the idea, form, and direction for the student.	N7 Blind acceptance of fluent AI outputs; no questioning of bias or correctness.	N8 AI use ignores equity, privacy, or community impact. AI amplifies transactional, coercive dynamics or inequities.
Lens	Meaning vs. erased context	Builds vs. replaces thinking	Makes vs. merely receives	Voice vs. ventriloquism	Iterate openly vs. conceal failure	Possibility vs. outsourcing	Inquiry vs. credulity; Preserve meaning vs. automate meaning	Responsibility vs. neglect; Strengthen community vs. erode community

Codes: Q = Question | P = Positive (Supports intrinsic reward) | N = Negative (Substitutes for intrinsic reward) | Hypothetical = an illustrative example | Actual = from actual story on other side

Core principle: If AI replaces the work of learning, it undermines learning—even if it appears efficient.

How These Dimensions Showed Up Over Time

These entries show which questions and examples were most relevant during each phase.

Phase	Cultural	Cognitive	Constructive	Communicative	Confident	Creative	Critical	Civic
Pre-Pandemic Challenges – Pandemic Inspired Community Building (Fall 2019 – Spring 2022)		P2		Q4 (PubPlat)	N5			Q8 (PubPlat)
Pre-AI rebuild: Sabbatical and First Semester After Sabbatical (Fall 2022 – Fall 2023)	Q1	Q2, P2			P5			
Early AI integration: Experimenting with AI as “Coworker” (Spring 2024 – Spring 2025)	Q1, N1	Q2, N2, P2	Q3, P3, N3 (ROS)	P4, Q4, N4 (ROS)	Q5	Q6	Q7, N7 (ROS)	P8 (in groups)
Current practice: Visible AI Modeling and Shared Competence (Fall 2025 – Spring 2026)	P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P6	P7	P8 (in classroom)

Use this timeline to reflect on how AI use has shifted across phases—and where it may currently be supporting or substituting for learning.

Parenthetical notes correspond to underlined items in the following timeline.

Timeline overview:

Pre-Pandemic Challenges – Pandemic Inspired Community Building (Fall 2019 – Spring 2022)

- Learning Assistants (LAs) and automated publisher platforms to manage workload and grading during a new class preparation. (PubPlat)
- Pandemic-era online: **students primarily lacked community, shared presence, & mutual care.**
- Result: **design learning as a social process.**
- To support students: **HyFlex models & annotated video lectures** & intentional social networking

Pre-AI rebuild: Sabbatical and First Semester After Sabbatical (Fall 2022 – Fall 2023)

- Became convinced AI would **rapidly and significantly reshape the labor market.**
- Results: (1) **reconsider core purpose of higher education** & for what we prepare students (2) **loss of confidence in their students' future job prospects.**
- Students **bypassed their carefully annotated video lectures** by simply reading AI-generated Zoom summaries - **materials were being circumvented by the technology itself**, not by students.

Early AI integration: Experimenting with AI as “Coworker” (Spring 2024 – Spring 2025)

- Built custom chatbots prompted to act as **“ideal fellow classmates” and collaborative peers.**
- Students were assigned group work where the AI acted as a group member, & students had to reflect on & evaluate the AI's contributions. This resulted in AI contributing to positive authentic student community. (P8 in groups)
- **Maintaining the chatbots' knowledge bases was exhausting:** delegated this to LAs.
- In one class experiment, spent only a single day showing students how to study with AI, which resulted in **students successfully using AI independently outside of class.**
- Despite its apparent success, I felt this was **deeply wrong, unhealthy, and lacked crucial instructor modeling**, realizing solitary AI use was unwise.
- Some students from a different institution took a HyFlex class entirely asynchronously. They used AI to do all work & refused requests for synchronous sessions or submission of videos that included their face narrating an explanation. At the time this didn't violate my syllabus policies so I couldn't penalize them. Later classes were not listed as HyFlex to deter such students (ROS – remote only students).

Current practice: Visible AI Modeling and Shared Competence (Fall 2025 – Spring 2026)

- Scrapped previous solitary AI: focused exclusively on **modeling AI use visibly during class time.**
- By intentionally coming to class less prepared, demonstrated how to **fill knowledge gaps with AI in real-time, narrating their process of critiquing and revising its outputs.**
- Classroom design shifted toward active learning and **short in-person presentations**, where students could use AI to prepare but had to demonstrate competence during an open Q&A.
- The combination of instructor demonstrating responsible AI use & students performing it reinforced social norms about its use, creating a positive sense of authentic civic community (P8 in classroom)
- Because technology development is a social process, **technology use must also be communal** to establish shared norms of competent practice.
- Ultimately, concluded that **AI integration depends entirely on a strong relational foundation**; without authentic trust and collaboration, AI will simply amplify coercive classroom dynamics.